

8.3 SOME DIALOGUES IN CONTEXTS

[Adapted from the book entitled *Spoken English: A Self-Learning Guide to Conversation Practice* by V. Sasikumar, & P. V. Dhamua]

AT THE POST OFFICE

- RUBUL : Excuse me.
- COUNTER CLERK : Yes?
- RUBUL : I want to send this letter, please.
- COUNTER CLERK : Do you want to send it by general letter post or registered post? It'd be five rupees by general letter post, and twenty-five rupees up to 20 grams by registered post.
- RUBUL : You'd better send it by registered letter post. It might be quicker.
- COUNTER CLERK : All right. Anything else I can do for you?
- RUBUL : Yes. Could you weigh this letter, please?
- COUNTER CLERK : It's just over 30 grams. It'll cost you twenty eight rupees. Here're the stamps for the letter. Will you affix them, please?
- RUBUL : I also want twenty inland letter sheets and ten stamped envelopes.
- COUNTER CLERK : But, wait a minute, please. Let me first give you the receipt for the registered post. Here's the receipt. And, here's the postal stationery that you are in need of. However, don't forget to put the letter in the box over there.
- RUBUL : Oh, yes. Thank you very much.

AT THE DOCTOR'S

- PATIENT : Good evening, doctor.
- DOCTOR : Good evening, sir. What's your trouble?
- PATIENT : I haven't been feeling well lately.

- DOCTOR : What exactly is the problem?
- PATIENT : I often feel quite sick. I've had a lot of pain in the stomach for several days. I've also had severe headaches for over two days.
- DOCTOR : What's your appetite like?
- PATIENT : Not at all good. I don't feel like eating anything. I feel full up all the time.
- DOCTOR : Have you had any fever?
- PATIENT : Well, I do feel feverish all the time. I've also had a bad taste in the mouth since I've fallen sick.
- DOCTOR : All right, let me take your temperature first. There! Give me your wrist, please. There's nothing wrong with the pulse. Now take off your pullover. And, your shirt too. Loosen your clothes a little. I'll examine you, if you lie down on that couch. Do you feel any pain here?
- PATIENT : Yes, some.
- DOCTOR : And here?
- PATIENT : Oh, that's quite painful!
- DOCTOR : All right. You may get dressed now.
- PATIENT : I hope there's nothing serious, doctor?
- DOCTOR : No, nothing serious. I'm prescribing two kinds of tablets. Take one before meals. And, the other after meals for three days. Don't eat any fried or spicy food. Drink milk and have milk foods as much as you can. And, do take some rest.
- PATIENT : Do I need to stay away from work, doctor?
- DOCTOR : No, not at all. Just take it easy and have rest whenever you can. Come and see me again if the trouble continues.
- PATIENT : Thank you very much, doctor. Good-bye!
- DOCTOR : Bye! Take Care.

BUYING A SHIRT

- SHOP ASSISTANT : Good afternoon, madam. What can I do for you?
- CUSTOMER : Good afternoon, I'd like to buy a shirt.
- SHOP ASSISTANT : Cottons or synthetics, madam?
- CUSTOMER : Terycots, if you have some.
- SHOP ASSISTANT : Sure, madam. Over here, if you don't mind. We have an excellent range of shirts in terycot. These striped ones are new arrivals.
- CUSTOMER : I rather fancy those blue ones with red stripes.
- SHOP ASSISTANT : Well, they're men's shirts. But, nowadays . . .
- CUSTOMER : Could you take them out, please?
- SHOP ASSISTANT : What's the collar-size, madam?
- CUSTOMER : Fifteen.
- SHOP ASSISTANT : Fifteen? Are you sure, madam?
- CUSTOMER : Yes. I'm sure.
- SHOP ASSISTANT : Here you are, madam.
- CUSTOMER : How much is it?
- SHOP ASSISTANT : That's five hundred and nineteen rupees. Plus taxes. Would you like to try it on?
- CUSTOMER : Try it on? No. Could you gift-wrap it? You see, it's a gift to my husband on his birthday!
- SHOP ASSISTANT : I see! (Later) Here it is! I've stuck on it a little card saying 'Happy Birthday!'
- CUSTOMER : That's very kind of you, young man. Bye!
- SHOP ASSISTANT : Good-bye, madam. Call again.

AT THE MARKET

- JANAKI : (to her husband Bolin). Why don't we come to the market more often?
- BOLIN : I don't find it a very enjoyable place.
- JANAKI : But I do. I want to come here every day.
- BOLIN : Come here every day, then. Who stops you? You have nothing better to do . . .

Express is running four hours late.

AT THE TEA STALL

- CUSTOMER : What's the idea? I've been waiting for half an hour now. Do you want me to wait forever?
- OWNER : I'm sorry, sir. I'll give you your tea in a few minutes.
- CUSTOMER : But I can't wait any more.
- OWNER : I haven't served tea to anybody who's come after you. Everybody here waits for his turn. If I served you out of turn, the other customers who came before you would complain.
- CUSTOMER : All right, I'll wait for my turn, but you should work a little faster.
- OWNER : Here's your tea, sir. Would you like some biscuits or some namkin to go with it?
- CUSTOMER : Yes, I think I need some biscuits, some good biscuits, if you have any.
- OWNER : I have Eatwell Glucose and Sultana Bikis. Which would you like?
- CUSTOMER : Well, give me two or three Sultanas.
- OWNER : All right, sir.
- CUSTOMER : God, how dirty this plate is! Look here. Its edges are broken, and it's covered with grease, ash, and grime.
- OWNER : I'm sorry, sir. But . . .
- CUSTOMER : Take this plate away. I don't need any of your biscuits.
- OWNER : May I bring you another cup of tea, sir?
- CUSTOMER : Do you think I can survive this cup to order another?
- OWNER : What's the matter with this tea, sir?
- CUSTOMER : What's the matter? It's bad... It's over boiled and bitter. I wonder if you've mixed any sugar at all.

- MOHAN : Good afternoon.
- ENQUIRY CLERK : Good afternoon. What can I do for you, sir?
- MOHAN : What time is the Andhra Pradesh Express expected?
- ENQUIRY CLERK : The scheduled time of its arrival is 4 o'clock.
- MOHAN : But it's already fifteen minutes past four and there's yet no sign of its arrival.
- ENQUIRY CLERK : I'm afraid it's running late by over an hour, and we've already announced it's running late.
- MOHAN : I haven't heard any such announcement. I've been at the station for over ten minutes.
- ENQUIRY CLERK : Perhaps, it was made before you came. Let me check...It was made at 3.55, exactly 20 minutes ago.
- MOHAN : Do you make only oral announcements?
- ENQUIRY CLERK : No, we also write them on the notice board just in front of the ASM's office.
- MOHAN : Don't you think these announcements should be a little more frequent?
- ENQUIRY CLERK : Well, I can't answer that question. For that, you can speak to the ASM, if you like.
- MOHAN : Very well. When exactly will the train arrive?
- ENQUIRY CLERK : At 5.10. This is the position at the moment. But, it may cover some time, or it may be delayed further. We'll make another announcement as soon as we receive a message.
- MOHAN : This will mean a lot of inconvenience to the people gathered here. Have you thought of that?
- ENQUIRY CLERK : I'm sorry, but I can't help it. Bear with me for some more time, please, and make yourself comfortable in the waiting room.
- MOHAN : All right. Thank you.

On the public-address system: Your attention, please. The North East

IN THE LIBRARY

STUDENT

: I want to return these four books.

LIBRARY ASSISTANT

: But two of these were due on Monday. You're late by three days. I'm afraid you'll have to pay the fine.

STUDENT

: Oh yes, I know that. But... I was sick and have not been able to come to college these four days. You condone the delay under special circumstances, don't you? And my sickness is a special circumstance, isn't it?

LIBRARY ASSISTANT

: Yes, it is. But you should talk to the librarian. My duty is just to charge the fine if it is due according to the rules.

STUDENT

: Very well, I'll see the librarian. Meanwhile, please issue me with these two books. Oh, wait a minute. I want another book too. Let me go to the racks and find out that one also.

LIBRARY ASSISTANT : OK, I'll wait and lend you all the three together.

STUDENT (later) : Here's the book I wanted. Now please issue them.

LIBRARY ASSISTANT : Would you sign here, please? And here also?

STUDENT

: Oh, I want to point out something. In this book, one page is missing. It's page 231. You can have a look.

LIBRARY ASSISTANT : Somebody has torn it away! How callous! ... I must stamp page 230 to indicate that page 231 has been torn out.

STUDENT

: Is this necessary?

LIBRARY ASSISTANT : Yes, very necessary. Otherwise this may be blamed on you, or the next borrower after you.

STUDENT

: Thanks very much.

LIBRARY ASSISTANT

: That's all right.

AT THE RAILWAY STATION

- JANAKI : Now, don't shout, dear. I didn't say I *will* come here every day; I said I *want* to come here.
- BOLIN : Let's not argue any more. Let's quickly do the shopping and go home. The children must be getting impatient.
- JANAKI : OK, here's the shopping list. We'll first buy toiletries and groceries and then go to the vegetable stall.
- BOLIN : That's right. Let's go to the department store next door.
- SHOP ASSISTANT : What can I do for you, madam?
- JANAKI : We're new to this store and we don't know where things are. Can you tell us where the groceries are? And the toiletries?
- SHOP ASSISTANT : For the groceries turn right, madam, and then walk straight on until you come to the end of the corridor. And for the toiletries, just turn left and you walk right into them.
- JANAKI : Thanks.
- BOLIN : I want these 15 items. Please make me the bill quickly.
- COUNTER CLERK : I'll take only a minute, sir. Here's the bill.
- JANAKI : Most of the vegetables I wanted to buy are stale. Some of them are even rotten. You should've thrown them away.
- COUNTER CLERK : Sorry, madam. In fact, yesterday the wholesale market was closed, and so we couldn't bring in fresh supplies.
- JANAKI : But that doesn't mean you should sell rotten vegetables.
- COUNTER CLERK : Sorry, madam.
- JANAKI : I won't come to this place again.
- BOLIN : Not until next week! Bye!

RAMESH
MECHANIC

: But the mixture is ignited, isn't it?
Yes, but probably the mixture doesn't burn long enough to start the engine. And sometimes even when the engine gets started, it soon runs down since the supply of fuel is cut off.

RAMESH

: OK, I'll take your word for it. Start working on it right away. Can you give the scooter back to me in two hours?

MECHANIC

: I don't think I can, sir, but I'll certainly try.

RAMESH

: By the way, what'll be your charge?

MECHANIC

: Not much, sir. It'll be only fifty rupees.

RAMESH

: Fifty rupees? But it's only a minor repair.

MECHANIC

: It is a major repair, sir. The carburettor has to be cleaned up. The parts around it have to be cleaned up too, and then the carburettor has to be adjusted. This will mean a lot of trial and error. Two of my boys will be busy handing me tools and things.

RAMESH

: Oh, you make the work sound so heavy and complicated!

MECHANIC

: I just don't make it sound so; it is heavy and complicated.

RAMESH

: All right. Do it then, please.

MECHANIC

: Right away, sir!

HIRING A TAXI

TD

: Taxi-driver

P

: Passenger

P

: Taxi, taxi!

TD

: Yes, sir? Would you like to hire the taxi, sir?

P

: No, I just want to make an enquiry. Where can I find a taxi for the airport?

TD

: Well, you have it right here. I can take you to the airport. Which airport, sir?

- in mind, the one written by John Brown?
- C : Oh, not at all. I mean the world-famous novel by the great Russian novelist Dostoevsky. I doubt if there is any history book of this name. I think you're mixed up.
- SA : Oh dear, I'm really mixed up. I'm sorry, sir. Perhaps I should've been a little more careful.
- C : Now, don't worry about that. Tell me how long it will take you to get me a copy of the book. I need it soon.
- SA : If you could give me two weeks' time . . . I'll place the order right away.
- C : Thank you... Could you guide me to your fiction department? I'd like to browse through some of your latest arrivals, and may select some of them to buy.
- SA : Yes, by all means, sir. From here, you just move straight down and then turn left. You'll find fictions there on both sides.
- C : Where exactly can I find the latest arrivals?
- SA : In the beginning of the corridor, on either side. You'll find a boy there. He'll help you, I'm sure.
- C : Thanks.

AT THE GARADGE

- MECHANIC : I've checked everything, sir, and it's definitely the carburettor. Everything else has been found fine. The battery is fully charged. The ignition plug is all right. It gives out a nice spark.
- RAMESH : But what's the carburettor to do with the starting trouble?
- MECHANIC : Oh, it's everything to do, sir. It's here that the mixture is ignited.

A

VINOD

: Can you name some of these subjects?

: Yes, sociology, for example. Or education, psychology. Or still more useful and career-oriented subjects like business management, social work, journalism, international understanding, oceanography.

B

VINOD

: But do you think you can mention social work and oceanography together, in the same breath?

: Oh, I just named them as they came to me, at random. I wasn't in any way attempting a classified list.

C

: Can you tell me why you're interested in an administrative career? Most candidates for jobs try their luck at everything and plump for whatever job they can lay their hands on. They don't care whether they are fit for a certain career or not.

VINOD: Well, I don't know much about others. I'm taking this interview because I'd, any day, prefer an administrative position to any other. B: Why?

VINOD

: Well, I think I'm good at getting things done rather than doing them myself. A: That's a good answer!

Thank you.

VINOD

: Thank you.

AT THE BOOK SELLER'S

SA: Shop Assistant

C: Customer

C

: Do you, by any chance¹, have *Crime and Punishment*, please?

SA

: I'm afraid it's sold out.

C

: Sold out? I don't think it's possible. This book cannot be in such great demand.

SA

: Wait a minute, sir. Do you have the history book

- I've never taken worse tea in my life.
- OWNER : Nobody's ever told me anything about my plates and tea. You're the first person to make a complaint and I promise to be careful in future, sir.
- CUSTOMER : I hope you'll keep your promise. How much do I pay for the tea?
- OWNER : Nothing, sir. Thanks a lot for your comments. You can pay me next time.
- CUSTOMER : Thanks.

AN INTERVIEW

- VINOD (Interviewee) : Good morning.
- INTERVIEWERS (A, B, C, D, E): Good morning.
- A : Please sit down.
- VINOD : Thank you.
- B : Please tell us your name.
- VINOD : I'm Vinod Sharma.
- C : Your name gives the impression that you're a very learned man.
- VINOD : I wish I were. If only names could be an index of the mind of the people who bear them.
- D : What about your name? Do you think it indicates your personality?
- VINOD : I can't answer that question, but I'm sure I can't make any claim to any great learning or knowledge that my name . . .
- E (interrupting him) : Well, don't worry about your name. Please tell me what subjects you studied for your B.A.
- VINOD : History, economics and political science.
- E : I wonder why most of you offer these subjects.
- VINOD : That's because most colleges teach only these subjects. They have no facilities to teach certain subjects which most of us would like to study.

AT THE HOTEL

- TOURIST : Good morning. Have you any room vacant?
- RECEPTIONIST : Yes, sir. Double or single?
- TOURIST : I want one double.
- RECEPTIONIST : I have a double room on the second floor.
- TOURIST : Oh, but I wanted to have one on the ground floor, or the first floor.
- RECEPTIONIST : Let me see if I can . . . I'm sorry, sir. There's no double room vacant at the moment either on the ground or on the first floor. But I wonder if' you could wait till the check-out time. I'll have two vacancies then. Could I book one of the rooms for you in advance, sir?
- TOURIST : Yes, I don't mind waiting for an hour or so. What's your check-out time?
- RECEPTIONIST : It's 12 noon, and it's already a quarter past eleven. So you'll have to wait for less than an hour, sir.
- TOURIST : How come? My watch shows ten minutes to eleven! That means there's more than an hour to go. I'm not going to wait. . .
- RECEPTIONIST : I'm afraid² your watch is a little too slow, sir. My watch makes 11.20 now. I set the time only a few minutes before you came.
- TOURIST : Oh, dear, there's something wrong with my watch. You're right. I'll wait for some time.
- RECEPTIONIST : Thank you, sir. Would you take a seat, on the sofa over there?
- TOURIST : Oh, but I don't know anything about the facilities you provide here.

1. I wonder if: a polite way of making a request.

2. I'm afraid: a polite way of stating an unpleasant thing.

- RECEPTIONIST : Don't worry about that, sir. Here's a brochure giving all information about the hotel. On page ten, you'll

COUNTER CLERK : What's the amount? Let me see the cheque. It's less than two thousand. Go to the teller's counter, sir. She'll cash it right away.

CUSTOMER (at the teller's counter): Take this cheque please, and give me the amount. Be a little prompt, will you? I've already spent some time here going from counter to counter, and I'm in a hurry.

TELLER : All right, sir. Bear with me for two minutes, and I'll give you the money. (After a minute) I'm sorry to bother you, sir, but there's an over-writing on the date, which you've not signed. Would you put your signature here, just over the date on the right-hand corner?

CUSTOMER : Of course. Here it is, young lady. Now go ahead and pay the amount, please.

TELLER : It shouldn't take much time now. An entry has to be made, and that's all. But could I bother you again? Would you sign on the back of the cheque, here?

CUSTOMER : Certainly not. Why do you want me to sign on the back when I've put my signature on the front of the cheque?

TELLER : We need this signature as evidence that you've received the money, sir. The signature on the front only means that you've ordered the bank to pay.

CUSTOMER : Well, you have a point there, but this order should be enough evidence that the payment has been made.

TELLER : But it doesn't prove who's received it, does it?

CUSTOMER : That's true.

TELLER : Here's the amount, sir. Sorry for the little delay.

CUSTOMER : That's all right. Thank you.

TOM : Come, everybody. Let's have some tea now.

AT THE RESTURANT

- JOHN : Well, here we are. Do you like the place?
- MUKESH : Lovely! Very nice!
- JOHN : Ah, I hoped you would like this place. Let's go and sit in the corner there, shall we?
- MUKESH : Yeah.
- JOHN : Now then, let's see if we can get some service.
- MUKESH : Well, we need a menu first, don't we?
- JOHN : We haven't got one here, have we? Could you ask those people behind us?
- MUKESH : Mm, excuse me, could you possibly give us a menu? Oh, they haven't got one either!
- JOHN : Haven't they? Let me see ... I think I'll ask these people on my right. Um, sorry to interrupt. I wonder if you could give us a menu. Oh, they don't seem to have one either.
- MUKESH : We'd better get the waiter. I say . . . Waiter!
- WAITER : Yes, sir?
- MUKESH : Er, we haven't got a menu.
- WAITER : Oh, I'm sorry. I'll bring you one straight away.
- MUKESH : Thank you.
- WAITER : Here's the menu, sir. Er, I'm very sorry to trouble you, but I wonder if you could possibly move to another table. I'm afraid this table is reserved.
- JOHN : Oh yes, by all means.
- WAITER : Thank you very much, sir. Ah! here's the menu. You were sitting on it, sir.

AT THE BANK

- CUSTOMER : Can I cash a cheque here?
- COUNTER CLERK : Go to another counter, sir. That one there.
- CUSTOMER (at the second counter): Can I cash this cheque, please?

- P : Indira Gandhi International Airport.
- TD : Indira Gandhi International, or the other one for domestic flights?
- P : The International. What'd be the fare?
- TD : I'll charge by the meter-reading. It'd come to between thirty and forty rupees.
- P : Why *between* thirty and forty? Why not thirty or forty? You should be taking passengers to the airport every day. You should know what exactly the fare will come to.
- TD : I do, sir. And that's why I'm saying it'd come to between thirty and forty.
- P : But why?
- TD : Because the taxi doesn't cover exactly the same distance every time it goes from this taxi stand to the airport.
- P : But why? What's the mystery there? You mean to say that the road from this point to the airport is flexible? Does it expand and contract with the temperature like a rubber band, or something?
- TD : Come on, sir. There's no mystery at all, sir. It's straight and simple. The airport is quite far from here. The distance travelled, as the meter records it, will depend upon the lane you travel in, the number of times you change lanes, the number of times you overtake, and so on.
- P : All right, all right. Let's go. Would you help me with these bags?
- TD : By all means, sir. Let's put them in the boot, sir. Here... That's right. Now take your seat, sir... Are you comfortable enough, sir? Can I start?
- P : Yes, you can.